financiers to offer retail loan products to achieve the much-needed rural reach.

Striking the right balance between rising costs, quality and productivity was a complex task. To achieve this, when the Nano was launched, Tata Motors acknowledged that there wasn't any 'profit margin on the base model; profits [would] come from customers' who booked the deluxe model instead. The company was counting on high sales volumes to generate meaningful earnings. They were hoping that the car would rewrite the rules of the game. Ratan knew that if the car was positioned and marketed well, it could upend conventional assumptions and establish new standards in automobile manufacturing.

But despite all the publicity, euphoria and innovation, the sales fell short of expectations. Once the rush of the initial bookings was over, fresh orders dried up.

The delay caused due to the shifting of the factory from Singur resulted in the diversion of the technical capital to crisis management. It left little time to test the rigour of the product itself. Much of the time was spent firefighting. Talking about how disastrous the delay was, Ratan said in 2014: 'When we created the Nano, there was a lot of global excitement that a car could be offered at a price of $2,500 and three lakh orders with a waiting period of two years was induced. But it took another year because of the shift and there was a general disbelief generated about the car, while competitors got a chance to start badmouthing the Nano. By that time, much of the excitement was lost.'

The shift from Singur to Sanand took over a year. If production would have continued in Singur, the story would have been different, says Kant; because of the delay, the 'excitement petered [out]'.

Voicing the same opinion, Wagh says that the eighteen-month wait from January 2008 to July 2009, when the vehicle became commercially available, created doubts in people's minds whether the Nano was for real or if it was only a prototype production. Further, in less than a week of its launch, the company had got over one lakh bookings, when the production capacity was only thirty thousand cars per year. This high demand generated complacency in Tata Motors, which felt no compulsion to explain to the customer the reasons for the delay of nearly two years. This led many to believe that the car would not be available, Wagh adds.